2026 PLATFORM RESEARCH REPORT

The Trading Journal Deep Dive

Twelve platforms benchmarked on analytics depth, automation, journaling workflow and value — with a complete blueprint of the dashboard, trade log, analytics, psychology and playbook layers a great trade journal must have.

Z.ai Research
Independent platform analysis for the personal trading desk

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1 · Executive Summary and Verdict

This report audits twelve trading journal platforms as they stand in late 2026, priced and feature-checked against vendor pages and independent reviews between October and November 2026. The lens is deliberately personal: a multi-asset trader (stocks, futures, forex and crypto) whose primary criterion is **analytics depth**, buying for their own desk rather than for a firm. Alongside the head-to-head comparison, Chapter 6 distills what the accumulated best practice of these twelve products says a trade journal *must* look like — the dashboard, the trade log, the analytics module, the psychology layer and the playbook — so the blueprint can be applied to any tool you choose, or to a spreadsheet you build yourself.

If you need…	Buy this	Runner-up	Why
Maximum analytics per dollar	**TradesViz Platinum**	Tradervue Gold	600+ statistics, custom dashboards and an options backtester for roughly $270/year
An AI that journals for you	**TradeZella Pro**	TraderSync Premium	AI agents auto-tag every trade and write session reviews; 500+ broker imports
Psychology and discipline	**Edgewonk**	RizeTrade Essential	Tiltmeter, Psychology Lab and weekly Edge Finder scans for $197/year, everything unlocked
A genuinely free start	**Tradervue Free**	Stonk Journal	100 imported trades per month at zero cost — enough to build the habit properly
Options income strategies	**TradesViz Platinum**	WingmanTracker	Multi-leg grouping and options-specific analytics without the $49/month specialist tax
A one-time purchase, no subscription	**TradingDiary Pro**	DIY spreadsheet	$149 once, desktop-licensed, with tax reports the web tools do not produce

Table 1 — Top picks at a glance, by what you actually need from a journal.

Four findings shape everything that follows.

600+
statistics in TradesViz — the largest analytics surface audited

500–3,000
monthly Zella AI credits by tier — AI has become the pricing gate

$197/yr
Edgewonk all-in price — every feature, no tiers, no gating

100/mo
free imported trades on Tradervue — the best $0 tier in the industry

First, analytics depth is now table stakes at the top of the market. TradesViz exposes more than 600 statistics, Tradervue ships over 100 reports with full MFE/MAE exit analysis, and TradeZella claims 300+ reports. Differentiation has moved from "does it compute win rate" to how finely results can be segmented by setup, session, symbol and behavior — and to whether the tool surfaces patterns for you or waits for you to query them.

Second, AI moved from gimmick to gate. Every major platform except Tradervue and Stonk Journal now ships an AI layer, and pricing increasingly sells AI capacity rather than analytics: TradeZella allocates 500 to 3,000 AI credits per month by tier, TraderSync meters its Cypher assistant at 5 to 15 messages per day and reserves the Cypher Coach for the $79.95 Elite plan. You are no longer just buying a database with charts; you

are buying how much machine attention your trades receive.

Third, the market has bifurcated. Focused tools cluster at $15–20 per month (TradesViz, Trademetria, RizeTrade, Plancana), while AI-equipped suites run $35–100 (TradeZella, TraderSync). Edgewonk sits deliberately underneath both at $197 per year with a single tier that includes everything. A multi-asset trader who does not need AI agents can get top-decile analytics for less than half the price of the flagship suites.

Fourth, free tiers got real. Tradervue imports 100 stock trades per month for free and TradesViz allows 3,000 stock executions monthly on its Basic plan. Stonk Journal is free outright. The "try before you buy" problem that plagued this category for years has largely been solved — there is no longer a good reason to pay for a journal before verifying that it imports your broker's data cleanly.

2 · Why a Serious Journal Pays for Itself

A broker statement tells you **what** happened: net P&L;, fees, positions. A journal tells you **why** it happened — which setups earned the money, which hours of the day leak it, how often you broke your own rules, and what each broken rule cost. That attribution is the entire product. Without it, a trader with a 54% win rate and a positive month has no way of knowing that, say, Friday-afternoon revenge trades erased a third of the week's profit. With it, the same trader has an explicit, quantified instruction: stop trading Fridays after 15:00.

The arithmetic is unreasonably favorable. Edge in trading is a small number applied repeatedly, so modest improvements in expectancy compound dramatically. Consider a realistic active year:

240	+$9,600	80%
trades per year — a plausible 20 per month for an active retail trader	value of lifting expectancy by just +0.2R at $200 risk per trade	of that gain available from process fixes, not new strategies

No indicator, course or signal service offers a comparable return on $15–35 per month. The catch is that the journal only pays if the data is complete (automation), the metrics are honest (R-multiples and net-of-fees P&L;), and the review actually happens (workflow). Those three requirements — automation, honest metrics, enforced review — are the spine of both the evaluation in Chapter 3 and the blueprint in Chapter 6.

There are secondary payoffs beyond edge discovery. Discipline scores create accountability that a private notebook never achieves, because they are computed rather than remembered. Prop-firm traders need rule tracking to survive evaluations — TradeZella and TradesViz both market prop-compliance dashboards for exactly this reason. And a complete, exportable trade history is the cleanest input possible to tax reporting and to any future statistical or backtesting work you do.

3 · How We Evaluated

Twelve platforms were scored on five criteria, weighted to match the priorities stated for this research: analytics first, everything else second. Scores run 1–5 and are editorial judgments synthesized from each vendor's published feature set and pricing, cross-checked against independent reviews from StockBrokers.com, Tradeciety, TraderStack and Trader's Second Brain. They are estimates for comparison, not laboratory measurements.

Criterion	Weight	What we looked for
Analytics depth	30%	R-multiple support, expectancy and profit factor, MFE/MAE and exit-efficiency analysis, heatmaps by day/hour/setup, streak and drawdown statistics, custom segmentation, number of distinct reports
Automation and imports	25%	Broker coverage and auto-sync quality versus CSV file imports, options leg grouping, multi-account support, data export in open formats
Journaling and psychology	20%	Notes and screenshot workflow, tagging, emotion and mistake tracking, rule-adherence scoring, playbooks, pre-trade checklists
Ease of use	15%	Onboarding, interface clarity, mobile apps, whether the review workflow is structured or left to the user
Value for money	10%	Free tier generosity, annual pricing, feature gating across tiers, total cost of the tier needed for serious analytics

Table 2 — Evaluation criteria and weights. Analytics depth carries double the weight of any other criterion.

Two disclosures matter. Prices were verified on vendor pages on 4 November 2026 and change frequently — TradeZella repriced its entire lineup as recently as July 2026, and TraderSync runs perpetual promotions that cut the first year by 50–60%. And several "best trading journal" lists ranking highest in search are published by the journals themselves; where a claim in this report rests on a vendor's own marketing (trade counts, broker counts), it is marked as a claim.

4 · Platform Deep Dives

The six market leaders get the full treatment; six specialists follow in shorter form. Each profile opens with a fact strip (verified November 2026), then the analysis that matters for a multi-asset, analytics-first buyer.

4.1 TraderSync — the analytics suite with an AI coach

Price	Pro $29.95/mo · Premium $49.95/mo · Elite $79.95/mo. Annual billing cuts Pro to $312.60/yr; first-year promotions of 50–60% off are run regularly
Free tier	None. Full 7-day trial without a credit card
Assets	Stocks, options, futures, forex, crypto
Imports	700+ broker connections (claimed); broker sync plus file imports; native iOS and Android apps
Standout	Cypher AI assistant and Cypher Coach; Trade Replay and Market Replay backtesting with tick precision down to 250 ms on Elite; Level II, time-and-sales and screener widgets
Watch out	The AI coach is gated to Premium and Elite; no free tier; exports restricted during the trial

TraderSync is one of the two flagship all-in-ones, and its center of gravity is the replay environment. Market Replay reconstructs historical sessions across stocks, futures, crypto and forex with 1-minute candles on Pro, 1-second ticks on Premium and 250-millisecond updates on Elite, wrapped in a professional toolset — Level II, time and sales, screeners, watchlists. For a trader who learns by re-walking the tape, this is the deepest replay suite among the twelve, and StockBrokers.com's 4.0 review singles out its crisp design and the ongoing insights it generates from your own history.

The analytics layer is broad rather than surgical: detailed performance reports, an insights engine, a Strategy Checker for pre-planning trades with risk rules and time filters, and account-level analytics across up to five accounts on Pro. Tradeciety's critique is fair — the backtesting feels secondary to dedicated platforms and important features sit behind higher tiers — but the paid tiers are coherent: each one buys precision (faster replay, more Cypher, options tools) rather than random unlocks.

Cypher, the AI assistant, answers questions about your trading and (on Elite) proactively coaches. The 5–15 daily message limits will feel tight to heavy users, which is the point: TraderSync monetizes machine attention. Mobile apps make the post-session review loop the strongest of any suite here.

> **Verdict:** *the most complete replay-plus-coach ecosystem in the category. Buy Premium or Elite only if you will use Cypher and the replay tools weekly; the Pro tier alone duplicates what TradesViz does for less money.*

4.2 TradeZella — the AI-first all-in-one

Price	Essential $35/mo · Pro $59/mo · Ultra $99/mo. Annual billing: $315 / $531 / $891 (save 25%)
Free tier	None — no trial. First pricing change since 2022 (July 2026)
Assets	Stocks, options, futures, forex, crypto
Imports	500+ broker and prop-firm integrations with automated sync (claimed)
Standout	Zella AI agents — auto-tagging, session review, market sentiment — on Pro and above; 300+ reports; manual backtesting over 11+ years of data; tick-level trade replay; Prop Firm Sync; Zella University education library
Watch out	AI credits are metered (500–3,000/month); trade replay capped at 10/month on Essential; no free way to test before paying; web-first, no dedicated mobile app

TradeZella grew out of a public trading brand and behaves like a consumer product: 100,000+ traders, a claimed 20.2 billion trades journaled, a 4.8 Trustpilot score and a genuinely strong education arm. Its July 2026 repricing created three tiers — Essential at $35 (up from $29), Pro at $59 (up from $49) and a new Ultra at $99 — and the company's own framing is honest about what happened: the platform absorbed backtesting, replay, AI and prop-firm tracking, and now charges accordingly.

What is genuinely good: the journal builds itself. Connect accounts once and every fill imports automatically; the Strategies module organizes trades by playbook; weekly and monthly AI review reports arrive without being asked; and on Pro, the agent layer tags every trade, reviews every session and generates a pre-market plan. For prop-firm traders, Prop Firm Sync consolidates multiple funded accounts under one dashboard. As an automation proposition it is the strongest of the twelve.

The critique is the mirror image. At $35 with no trial, it is the most expensive way to start journaling, and the credit metering means heavy AI users are nudged toward Ultra ($1,188/year). Essential feels deliberately hobbled — ten replays a month, no agents — so the real product starts at Pro ($708/year). StockBrokers.com's 4.0 review also notes the broker integration, while broad, is not as turnkey as the marketing suggests, and there is no dedicated mobile app.

> **Verdict:** *the best choice when you want the machine to do the tagging, reviewing and summarizing for you, and you accept paying suite prices for it. Pro is the sweet spot; skip Essential.*

4.3 Tradervue — the old reliable

Price	Free · Silver $29.95/mo · Gold $49.95/mo (annual billing about $323/yr on Silver); 7-day trial on paid plans
Free tier	Yes — 100 stock trades per month, the most usable free tier in the industry
Assets	Stocks, options, futures, forex
Imports	80+ brokers; no MetaTrader sync
Standout	MFE/MAE statistics and exit-efficiency analysis; TradingView charts with entries and exits marked from weekly down to 1-minute; mentoring and community sharing
Watch out	No AI features at all; interface shows its age; options tracking is basic; psychology tooling absent

Tradervue has been running since 2011 and has accumulated more than 200,000 traders, and StockBrokers.com still ranks it the best trading journal overall. The reason is narrow and real: it answers the mechanical exit questions better than anyone. MFE (maximum favorable excursion) and MAE (maximum adverse excursion) statistics, exit analysis and max-potential P&L; reports quantify exactly how much money your exits leave on the table — the single highest-leverage analytics a developing trader can get, and one most competitors still do not match.

The workflow is the other strength: charts generate automatically around your entries and exits so you never take screenshots mid-session, tagging and filtering drill down into any slice, and the mentor-sharing features make it the default journal for coaching relationships. The free tier — 100 imported stock trades per month — is a real product, not a demo, which is why the standard advice for building the journaling habit starts here.

The gaps are the years. No AI anything, no MetaTrader sync, an interface that is functional rather than modern, and — as Tradeciety notes — zero psychology tooling. For an analytics-first buyer none of that is disqualifying; the exit-analysis suite alone keeps it in the top tier of this report's scoring.

> **Verdict:** *the safest subscription in the category. Start free, and upgrade to Gold only when exit analysis provably moves your numbers — for most traders it will.*

4.4 Edgewonk — the psychologist's journal

Price	$197/year or $35/month (EU/UK: $169 + VAT); 14-day money-back guarantee
Free tier	None — the guarantee replaces it
Assets	Forex, stocks, futures, crypto, indices, commodities, options
Imports	Unlimited trades, unlimited accounts and prop-firm accounts; file-based imports (no real-time broker API sync)
Standout	Tiltmeter discipline tracking and Psychology Lab; automated Edge Finder that scans your journal weekly; Trade Management Optimizer; alternative-strategy simulator; MFE/MAE reports; single tier with everything unlocked
Watch out	No mobile app, no trade replay, no AI chat; imports are file-based, which gets tedious at high trade frequency

Edgewonk comes from the Tradeciety team and runs on a deliberately contrary philosophy: one tier, everything included, no feature gating. In a market where the flagships now charge $35–99 per month and meter AI credits, $197 per year (about $16.40 monthly) for the complete product is the clearest value proposition in this report. The trade-off is architectural: imports are file-based rather than live API syncs, so you export from your broker and import — a non-issue for swing traders, a chore for hundred-trade-a-week scalpers.

The analytics are deep in the ways that matter: MFE/MAE, best-exit analysis, winning and losing streak analytics, drawdown analysis, trade-quality scoring, and a Trade Management Optimizer that replays your own trade management decisions against alternatives. But the differentiators are behavioral. The Tiltmeter quantifies how often you break your own rules; the Psychology Lab tracks discipline, mindset and routine as first-class metrics; and the Edge Finder scans your journal weekly and reports the strengths, weaknesses and improvement opportunities you have not noticed. No other platform treats behavior this seriously — RizeTrade comes closest.

What you give up: replay, backtesting, AI agents, mobile. What you get: the highest journaling and psychology score in the matrix (5/5), analytics within half a point of the leaders, and the second-highest weighted score overall — at roughly a quarter of the flagship suites' cost.

> **Verdict:** *the best pure-journaling value in the industry, and mandatory shortlisting if your edge is limited by discipline rather than by analysis.*

4.5 TradesViz — the stats engine

Price	Basic free · Pro $19.99/mo (about $15/mo billed annually) · Platinum $29.99/mo (about $22.50/mo annually)
Free tier	Yes — stocks only, 1 account, 3,000 executions per month, includes a free simulator
Assets	Stocks on the free tier; broader multi-asset and options coverage on paid tiers
Imports	Broker API sync, Plaid auto-sync and file imports; CSV/JSON export; native mobile apps
Standout	600+ statistics; fully custom dashboards and grids; AI coach and AI Q&A; backtester and options strategy backtester; seasonality screener; prop-firm compliance across 20 firms and 65 profiles
Watch out	Dense, engineer-flavored interface with a real learning curve; multi-asset is gated to paid plans

TradesViz is the analytics-per-dollar leader of this entire report. The product is essentially a quant workbench wearing a journal's clothes: more than 600 statistics, custom dashboards you assemble yourself, advanced metrics, exit insights, distributions by time and market condition, simulators, a general backtester, an options strategy backtester, a seasonality screener and fundamentals — plus an AI coach and AI Q&A; layered on top. Trader's Second Brain's 2026 review calls it "strong for breadth, replay and data-heavy review," which is precisely the profile of the buyer it suits.

The prop-firm tooling is quietly excellent: twenty firms and sixty-five evaluation and funded profiles are supported for rule compliance — the widest coverage audited. Exports in CSV and JSON mean your data stays yours, a criterion this report treats as non-negotiable (Chapter 6, principle 10). Mobile apps exist and are serviceable.

The price of all this surface area is the interface. TradesViz looks and feels like a power tool; Tradeciety flatly calls the design outdated, and first-time users report a genuine learning curve before the custom dashboards start paying rent. If you want hand-holding and polish, buy TradeZella. If you want the most numbers per dollar and are willing to assemble your own views, nothing else is close.

> **Verdict:** *for a multi-asset, analytics-first trader on a budget, the strongest single recommendation in this report — verify your imports on the free tier, then move to Platinum.*

4.6 Trademetria — the portfolio tracker that journals

Price	Free · Basic $19.95/mo ($169/yr) · Pro $29.95/mo ($249/yr)
Free tier	Yes — 30 orders/month, 1 account, 3 open positions
Assets	Stocks, options, futures, forex, crypto, CFDs
Imports	140+ brokers with auto-sync
Standout	Portfolio tracking across up to 50 accounts: deposits, withdrawals, dividends, cost basis, allocations, multi-currency; PnL simulator; gamified rule challenges; AI insights and assistant
Watch out	The free tier is a teaser (30 orders); no mobile app; the default dashboard is plain until customized

Trademetria has served 80,000+ users since 2016 and its differentiator is altitude: it journals trades but it tracks the whole portfolio. Deposits and withdrawals, dividends and fees, cost basis and open risk across up to fifty

accounts in multiple currencies — for a multi-asset trader with several brokers, that aggregation layer is the hook no pure journal matches. The PnL simulator replays your own history under hypothetical rules, and the challenges feature gamifies rule adherence in a way that sticks for some traders who ignore sober dashboards.

The journaling layer is competent rather than exceptional: daily and per-trade journals, strategy rankings, distributions by time and market condition, an AI assistant that writes journal entries from your trades. StockBrokers.com praises the customizable dashboard and reasonable pricing; the same review notes the free tier's 30-order cap makes it a demo in disguise. Analytics depth sits mid-pack against TradesViz and Tradervue, and psychology tooling is light.

> **Verdict:** *pick Trademetria when portfolio aggregation across many accounts matters as much as trade analytics; otherwise TradesViz delivers more analysis for similar money.*

4.7 Journalytix — the futures specialist

Price	$47/month or $399/year
Free tier	None
Assets	Futures-first, via connected platforms
Imports	Jigsaw daytradr, NinjaTrader 8, Tradovate, MT4/MT5, TSTTrader, XTrader, Stellar, IB TWS; data feeds from Rithmic, CQG, TT, GAIN
Standout	Real-time dashboard that streams fills within seconds; live audio news feed from 75+ sources; WYSIWYG journal with voice dictation
Watch out	Roughly 8 platform integrations; no automated pattern analysis, replay or backtesting; newer prop-firm APIs such as TopstepX on ProjectX are unsupported; the journalytix.com domain was unreachable at our November 2026 check — verify availability before subscribing

Journalytix was built by the Jigsaw Trading team, and the order-flow pedigree shows: it is the only journal in this report designed for use *during* the session rather than after it. Fills stream onto a real-time dashboard within seconds, a live audio news feed from 75+ sources plays over the session, and the journal itself is a WYSIWYG editor with voice dictation — speak your notes while the tape is live. For a scalper on NinjaTrader or daytradr, nothing else journals in the moment like this.

The limitations are equally structural. TradeTanto's 2026 analysis counts roughly eight supported platforms, no structured grading or tag-based analytics, and no replay, backtesting or automated insight discovery. At $47 per month it is priced against full suites while offering a specialist's scope, and it does not track the newer prop-firm infrastructure. Our November 2026 attempt to reach the vendor's pricing page found the domain parked, so confirm the product's current status before committing.

> **Verdict:** *a specialist tool for active futures traders who live inside Jigsaw or NinjaTrader and want in-session context; everyone else gets strictly more capability for less money elsewhere.*

4.8 Stonk Journal — the free minimalist

Price	Free, donation-supported
Free tier	The entire product
Assets	Anything — manual entry
Imports	None. Trades are entered one at a time by hand
Standout	Setup, target price, stop-loss, notes and a confidence level on every trade; clean design; 15-second registration
Watch out	No broker import or sync; analytics are basic; manual entry is the tax you pay

Stonk Journal is StockBrokers.com's pick as best free trading journal, and it earns it: donation-funded, well designed, and — unusually for a free tool — capable of actual analysis rather than mere record-keeping. The confidence-level field per trade is a genuinely good idea that several paid tools lack.

The constraint is data entry. One-at-a-time manual logging is sustainable to perhaps twenty trades a month; past that, the entry burden outweighs the price advantage over Tradervue's free tier, which imports automatically. There is no broker sync and never has been.

> **Verdict:** *the right first ninety days for a beginner building the journaling habit at zero cost; graduate to an importing tool once you clear roughly 30 trades a month.*

4.9 TradingDiary Pro — the desktop one-timer

Price	$149 one-time license (2 PCs, 1 year of upgrades); optional $49/year thereafter
Free tier	30-day full trial
Assets	Stocks, options, futures, forex
Imports	30+ brokers; automatic grouping of option legs into strategies
Standout	Permanent ownership and local data; net-asset-value, risk and country-specific tax reports — unique in this lineup; developed since 2009
Watch out	Windows desktop only; dated interface; upgrades are effectively a subscription; no psychology or AI features

TradingDiary Pro is the answer to subscription fatigue: $149 once, licensed for two machines, your data stays on your disk. Now seventeen years old, it remains the only journal in this report that produces country-specific tax reports, and its option-leg grouping into strategies predates the feature in several younger rivals.

The trade-offs are era-defining: a desktop application in a browser market, thirty-odd broker imports against web platforms claiming hundreds, and a journaling feature set that stops at notes and screenshots — no psychology scoring, no AI, no replay.

> **Verdict:** *buy it if you want permanent ownership, local data and tax reporting; skip it if you live on mobile or need the behavioral layer.*

4.10 RizeTrade — the discipline coach

Price	Free (1 account, 1 CSV import) · Essential $19/mo billed annually ($228/yr) · Pro $33/mo billed annually ($399/yr)
Free tier	Yes — limited to one account and one import
Assets	Multi-asset via imports
Imports	thinkorswim, Webull, Interactive Brokers, TradeStation, Tradovate, E*TRADE
Standout	Emotion tagging — revenge trade, FOMO, overtrading, early exit — with reports that price what your emotions cost; rule-adherence statistics per strategy; AI-assisted journaling
Watch out	Smaller ecosystem and community; voice notes gated to Pro; analytics depth is mid-pack

RizeTrade is the newest entrant that matters, and it attacks one thing: the gap between knowing your rules and following them. Where Edgewonk infers tilt from behavior, RizeTrade makes the emotional annotation the primary key — every trade can carry a revenge-trade, FOMO, overtrading or early-exit tag, and the platform then reports the P&L; those tags destroyed and the win-rate gap between rule-following and rule-breaking trades. That single number — "what did discipline cost me this quarter" — is the most actionable statistic in trading psychology.

It is young: the broker list is short, the community small, and the general analytics sit squarely mid-pack. As a second tool for a stats-first trader it is redundant; as a primary tool for a trader whose known leak is discipline, it is surgically correct.

> **Verdict:** *if discipline is the documented bottleneck, Essential at $228/year is the most focused purchase in this report.*

4.11 WingmanTracker — the options specialist

Price	$49/month, single plan; 30-day trial with money-back guarantee
Free tier	None
Assets	Options on equities only
Imports	CSV from Schwab, Fidelity, tastyworks, E*TRADE, Interactive Brokers, TD Ameritrade
Standout	Automatic grouping of trades into legs and positions; roll and adjustment tracking with true cost basis through complex sequences — covered calls, iron condors, the wheel
Watch out	Options only; CSV import only; no psychology layer; $588/year is the most expensive entry price audited

WingmanTracker solves the problem generalist journals fumble: multi-leg options bookkeeping. It groups legs into positions, follows rolls and adjustments, and maintains honest cost basis and breakevens through sequences that turn a normal trade log into spaghetti. If you run the wheel or roll condors for a living, this is the accounting layer.

Everything else about it is narrow: one $49 plan, CSV-only imports, no stocks, futures or forex, and no journaling depth beyond notes. TradesViz Platinum covers options broadly — including an options strategy backtester — for roughly half the annual price.

> **Verdict:** *buy only if options income strategies are your entire book and roll accounting is the bottleneck; otherwise TradesViz does more for less.*

4.12 Plancana — the mobile psychologist

Price	Free-forever plan · Basic $4.99/mo · Pro $14.99/mo (or $29.99/quarter)
Free tier	Yes
Assets	Forex, crypto, CFDs, equities — manual entry plus syncs
Imports	Real-time sync: MetaTrader 4 and 5, Bybit, TradeLocker, cTrader
Standout	Genuinely mobile-first (iOS and Android); an AI mentor that links mood, energy and stress to P&L; and flags revenge patterns before the next entry; tilt detection in real time
Watch out	Young app; options analytics are thin; analytics depth is the weakest of the paid tools audited

Plancana represents the new generation: a mobile-first journal whose AI mentor tracks your emotional state, correlates it with performance, and intervenes — "you revenge traded after a minor loss; 80% of your losses happen in this state; take fifteen minutes." The real-time syncs cover exactly the platforms retail forex and crypto traders actually use, and the price is aggressive.

The cost is depth. As a statistics engine it is the weakest paid tool in this report; it is a discipline coach with a competent journal attached. The sensible pattern is exactly the one its own comparison pages fight: run Plancana for the behavioral layer if tilt is your issue, and keep a stats-first platform for analysis.

> **Verdict:** *the best $15 a month a tilting forex or crypto scalper can spend — as a supplement or a starting point, not as your analytics engine.*

4.13 The DIY route — spreadsheets and Notion

The free alternative deserves a paragraph because it is still the most popular journal in the world: a spreadsheet or Notion template you own outright, with zero subscriptions and total privacy. The failure mode is equally well documented — metric formulas rot, imports are copy-paste, nothing produces heatmaps or MFE/MAE unless you build it, and the journal typically dies around week six when maintenance exceeds motivation. If you go this route, steal the field schema from Table 5 and the KPI definitions from Chapter 6, and defend a fixed weekly review slot. Above roughly thirty trades a month, a tool that imports automatically beats a spreadsheet you maintain by hand — your hourly rate for manual data entry is negative.

5 · Head-to-Head: Scoring and Pricing

5.1 Weighted scoring matrix

Scores are 1–5 editorial estimates per criterion (Chapter 3), weighted 30/25/20/15/10 and computed to two decimals. The weighting favors this report's stated priorities; a buyer who weighs automation first would see TradeZella and TraderSync close the gap on Edgewonk.

Platform	Analytics (30%)	Automation (25%)	Journaling (20%)	Ease (15%)	Value (10%)	Weighted
Edgewonk	4.5	3.0	5.0	4.0	4.5	**4.15**
TradeZella	4.0	4.5	4.0	4.5	3.0	**4.10**
TradesViz	5.0	4.0	3.5	3.0	4.5	**4.10**
TraderSync	4.5	4.5	3.5	4.0	3.0	**4.08**
Tradervue	4.5	3.5	3.0	3.5	3.5	**3.70**
RizeTrade	3.0	3.0	5.0	4.0	4.0	**3.65**
Trademetria	3.5	3.5	3.5	3.5	4.0	**3.55**
Plancana	2.5	3.5	4.5	4.0	4.0	**3.53**
TradingDiary Pro	4.0	3.5	2.5	3.0	4.0	**3.43**
Journalytix	3.0	3.0	4.0	4.0	2.5	**3.30**
WingmanTracker	3.5	3.0	2.0	4.0	3.0	**3.10**
Stonk Journal	2.0	1.0	2.5	4.0	5.0	**2.45**

Table 3 — Weighted scoring matrix. Analytics depth carries the heaviest weight, per the brief for this report.

5.2 What a year actually costs

List prices for the tier a serious multi-asset trader would realistically buy, annualized where the vendor offers annual billing. Promotions (TraderSync's perpetual 50–60% first-year discounts, for example) can cut year one substantially; the figures below are the steady-state cost.

Platform	Free option	Entry plan	Top plan	Entry-tier cost per year
Stonk Journal	Entire product	none	none	$0
TradingDiary Pro	30-day trial	$149 one-time	$49/yr upgrades	$149 (year 1)
Trademetria	30 orders/mo	Basic $19.95/mo	Pro $29.95/mo	$169 (annual billing)
TradesViz	3,000 exec/mo	Pro $19.99/mo	Platinum $29.99/mo	~$180 (~$15/mo annual)
Plancana	Free-forever plan	Basic $4.99/mo	Pro $14.99/mo	~$180 (Pro)
Edgewonk	14-day guarantee	$197/yr (or $35/mo)	same	$197
RizeTrade	Limited free	Essential $19/mo	Pro $33/mo	$228 (annual billing)
TraderSync	7-day trial	Pro $29.95/mo	Elite $79.95/mo	$312.60 (annual billing)
TradeZella	None	Essential $35/mo	Ultra $99/mo	$315 (annual billing)
Tradervue	100 trades/mo	Silver $29.95/mo	Gold $49.95/mo	~$323 (annual billing)
Journalytix	None	$47/mo	same	$399
WingmanTracker	30-day trial	$49/mo	same	$588

Table 4 — Annual cost of ownership at the entry paid tier (list prices, November 2026).

5.3 The value frontier

Plotting analytics depth against annual cost exposes the structure of the market instantly. TradesViz sits alone in the upper-left — near-maximum analytics at a mid-pack price. Edgewonk and TradingDiary Pro form a low-cost, high-analytics cluster that trades automation for price. The flagship suites (TraderSync, TradeZella, Tradervue) cluster at $310–325 with strong but not unmatched analytics, and the specialists scatter to the right — WingmanTracker's $588 is the price of options purity.

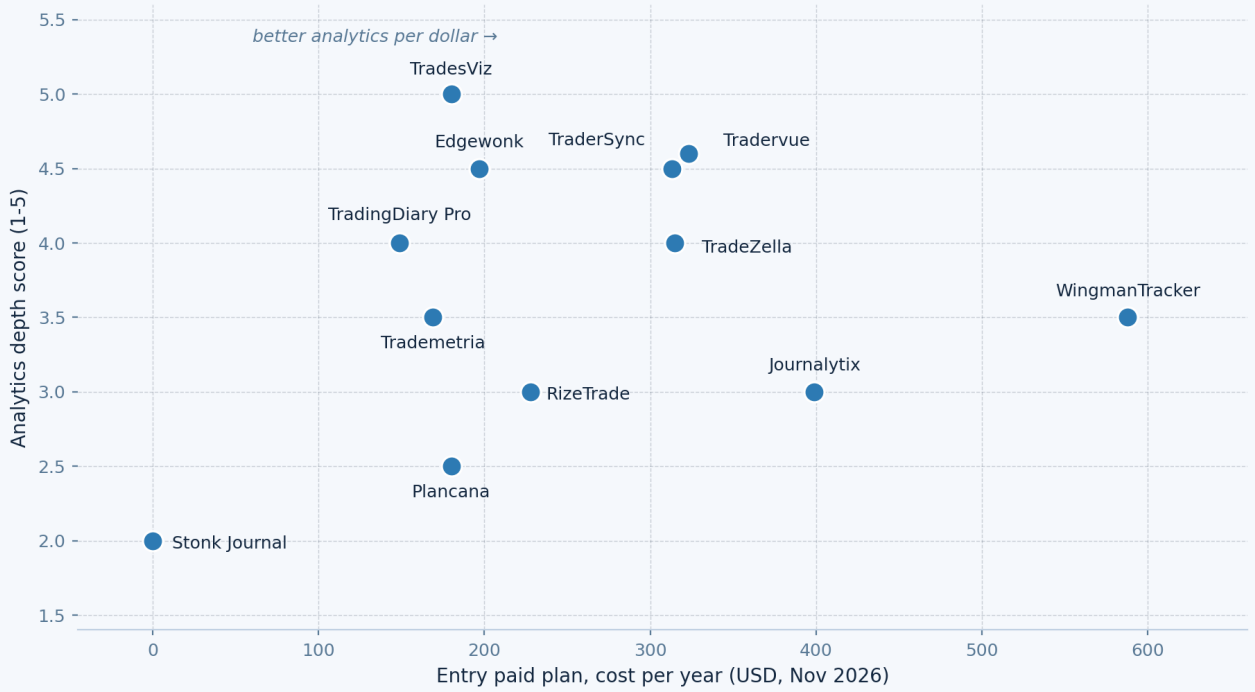


Figure 1 — The value frontier: analytics depth score versus annual cost of the entry paid tier. Upper-left is better. Sources: vendor pricing pages, November 2026.

6 · The Anatomy of the Ideal Trade Journal

Twelve platforms, audited end to end, converge on a surprising amount of common ground about what works. This chapter assembles that convergence into a blueprint: the ten principles every serious journal obeys, and the five screens a great one must have. Every figure in this chapter uses the same illustrative 120-day, 240-trade dataset so the numbers hang together — treat it as a worked example, not a case study.

6.1 Ten design principles

1. **Automatic first, manual second.** Every field a broker can populate should populate itself. The trader's keystrokes belong only to judgment fields — setup, grade, emotion, notes. Manual data entry is the number one journal killer.
2. **One screen answers "how am I doing?"** Six KPIs and one equity curve, visible without clicking. If the dashboard cannot answer that in five seconds, the review habit never forms.
3. **R-multiples are the unit of account.** Results normalized to risk (1R = the amount planned to lose) are the only way a multi-asset book compares a forex scalp with a swing trade in one distribution.
4. **Every trade gets a grade, not just a P&L.;** Process quality must be scorable independently of outcome — an A on a losing trade that honored the plan is a win; an F on a lucky one is a leak.
5. **Attribution or it didn't happen.** P&L; must slice by setup, session, symbol, emotion and rule adherence. The patterns those slices expose are the actual product.

6. **Negative space is a feature.** Each analytics view answers exactly one question. Dashboards that try to answer five questions at once answer none.
7. **Psychology is data, not diary.** Moods, tilt and rule violations are tags and scores — measurable, filterable, joinable to P&L.; Feelings that cannot be filtered cannot be fixed.
8. **The playbook is alive.** Setups carry rolling statistics and explicit kill rules. A journal that cannot tell you what to stop trading is a museum.
9. **Review is scheduled, not optional.** The tool must structure daily, weekly and monthly loops (Chapter 7). Otherwise it is a graveyard of good intentions.
10. **Your data is yours.** Export in open formats (CSV/JSON) at any time, at no price. A journal you cannot leave is a liability, not an asset.

6.2 The dashboard — six numbers and one curve

The dashboard is the screen you open every single session, so it earns the strictest design discipline. The KPI band below carries the six numbers that jointly describe a trading operation; anything else is a drill-down, not a headline. In the illustrative dataset, $25,000 grew to $37,945 (+51.8%) across 120 trading days — a good quarter that the profit factor (1.51) and expectancy (+0.45R per trade) confirm was earned by process rather than one lucky print.

+$12,945 net P&L; (+51.8% over 120 days)	**1.51** profit factor — gross wins over gross losses	**+0.45R** expectancy per trade	**54%** win rate across 240 trades
1.8R payoff ratio — avg winner +1.62R vs avg loser -0.91R	**-11.0%** maximum drawdown from equity peak	**56%** winning days out of 120	**+$3,891** net P&L; of the last 60 sessions

Dashboard KPI band — the six-plus numbers a trading dashboard must show at a glance (illustrative dataset used throughout this chapter).

Underneath the KPI band sits the equity curve with its underwater drawdown strip — the two-panel view every audited platform converges on. The curve answers "is the account growing"; the underwater strip answers "at what pain." A trader who sees -11% drawdown alongside +51.8% return knows the shape of the ride, which is what position sizing decisions are made of.



Figure 2 — The equity curve with underwater drawdown strip (illustrative data). First, last and peak equity are labeled; the drawdown panel quantifies the pain between peaks.

The daily P&L; bar strip completes the dashboard. It is deliberately the least processed view in the tool: green and red days in sequence, extremes labeled. Clustered red runs are visible here before they are visible in any statistic — the eye spots tilt patterns that aggregates bury.



Figure 3 — Daily net P&L; for the last 60 sessions (illustrative data). Streaks of red days are the visual signature of tilt and are often visible here first.

6.3 The trade log — every field that must be captured

The trade log is the atomic table of the journal, and its schema is the single most portable asset in this report — it applies identically to TradesViz, a spreadsheet or a notebook. Execution fields (rows 1–5) should auto-populate from imports; judgment fields (rows 6–13) are the trader's thirty seconds per trade. If logging a trade takes more than a minute, the journal dies — that constraint has killed more journals than any missing feature.

Field	Example	Why it matters
Date / time open and close	2026-10-14, 09:41 → 10:12	Session and timing attribution feeds the heatmaps
Symbol and direction	EURUSD, long	Instrument ranking and concentration analysis
Size and planned risk	2 lots, risk $200 (= 1R)	Converts every result into comparable R-multiples
Entry, exit and fees	1.0842 / 1.0871, fees $9	True net P&L; — gross numbers flatter everyone
Planned target	Target 2.0R, stop 1R	The plan the trade is graded against
Realized R	+1.45R	The outcome in currency-neutral units
MFE / MAE	+2.1R / -0.6R	Exit efficiency — how much the trade offered versus what you took
Setup tag	VWAP reclaim	Playbook statistics; the taxonomy from your trading plan
Rule adherence	Checklist 5/6	Discipline scoring, independent of outcome
Emotion tags	confident; slight FOMO on the add	Psychology attribution — feelings as filterable data
Mistake tag	moved stop once	Leak quantification: what each recurring mistake costs
Grade	B	Process quality on an A–F scale, scorable separately from P&L;
Screenshot	chart at entry and exit	Review evidence; auto-captured where the platform supports it
Notes	thesis, what broke, what to repeat	The actual journal — the sentence future-you needs most

Table 5 — The trade log schema. Fields 1–5 auto-populate from broker imports; fields 6–13 are the trader's judgment, roughly thirty seconds per trade.

6.4 The analytics module — where the edge is proven

Three definitions make everything in this section readable. **Expectancy** is the mean R of all trades — what one average trade is worth. **Profit factor** is gross profit divided by gross loss; above 1.5 over hundreds of trades is a robust business. **MFE/MAE** measure how far a trade traveled in your favor and against you before you exited — the raw material of exit analysis, and the reason Tradervue's fifteen-year reputation rests on solid ground.

The session heatmap is the highest-leverage single view in the journal. It crosses day-of-week with session and colors each cell by average R per trade — the matrix reads like a map of where your edge lives. In the illustrative dataset the edge concentrates Tuesday through Thursday in the US open block (up to +0.71R per trade) while the Friday close bleeds steadily (-0.61R). That is a schedule change worth more than most strategy changes, and it is invisible in any broker statement.

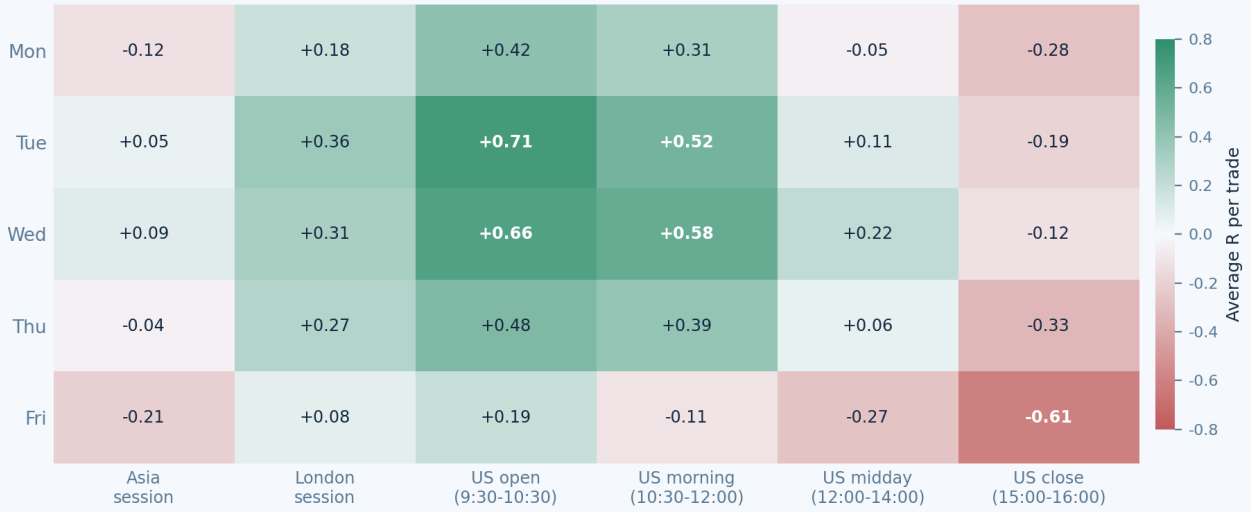


Figure 4 — The session heatmap: average R per trade by weekday and session (illustrative data). This single view often contains the cheapest edge improvement available.

The R-multiple distribution is the journal's balance sheet. The left tail shows risk control (-1R stops, honored); the right tail shows payoff (runners at +2R and beyond); the dashed line is expectancy — the business's unit economics. A distribution with a fat left tail beyond -1R is a discipline problem; a stunted right tail is a trade-management problem; both are fixable, and the histogram tells you which one to fix first.



Figure 5 — The R-multiple distribution of 240 trades (illustrative data): 54% winners, expectancy +0.45R, average winner +1.62R against average loser -0.91R.

6.5 The psychology layer — behavior as a measurable asset

The psychology layer is what separates the 2026 generation of journals from databases, and its design rule is principle 7: feelings must become filterable data. The mechanism is a small, closed taxonomy of emotion and mistake tags applied at trade entry (or auto-suggested by the AI layer on platforms that have one), which the analytics can then price.

Tag	What it catches	The metric to watch
Revenge trade	Re-entering within minutes of a stop	P&L; of the first 30 minutes after any loss
FOMO entry	Chasing an extended move without a setup	Win rate of tagged entries versus baseline
Overtrading	Trades beyond the daily plan or limit	P&L; of trades 4 and later within a day
Early exit	Cutting a winner before its target	Realized R versus MFE — the exit-efficiency gap
Stop moved	Widening invalidation after entry	Average outcome of moved-stop trades versus honored stops
Size violation	Position above the planned unit	Correlation between oversized trades and loss magnitude

Table 6 — A closed taxonomy of emotion and mistake tags. Six tags are enough; thirty ensure none get used.

Two aggregate scores roll the tags up. The **tilt score** (Edgewonk's Tiltmeter is the reference implementation) is a rolling share of rule-violating trades; when it rises, size goes down. The **discipline spread** is the expectancy of rule-following trades minus the expectancy of rule-breaking trades — in this illustrative dataset, +0.62R versus -0.79R, a gap of 1.4R per trade. That spread is, dollar for dollar, the most profitable number in the entire journal: closing half of it would outperform most new strategies.

6.6 The playbook — setups as living statistics

The playbook module treats each setup as a small business carrying its own rolling statistics: trade count, win rate, expectancy, and its current verdict. The chart below is the monthly review's single most important exhibit. Two setups in the illustrative book are paying for everything (opening range breakout at +1.34R per trade, VWAP reclaim at +0.93R); two are subsidized hobbies that must justify themselves or die.

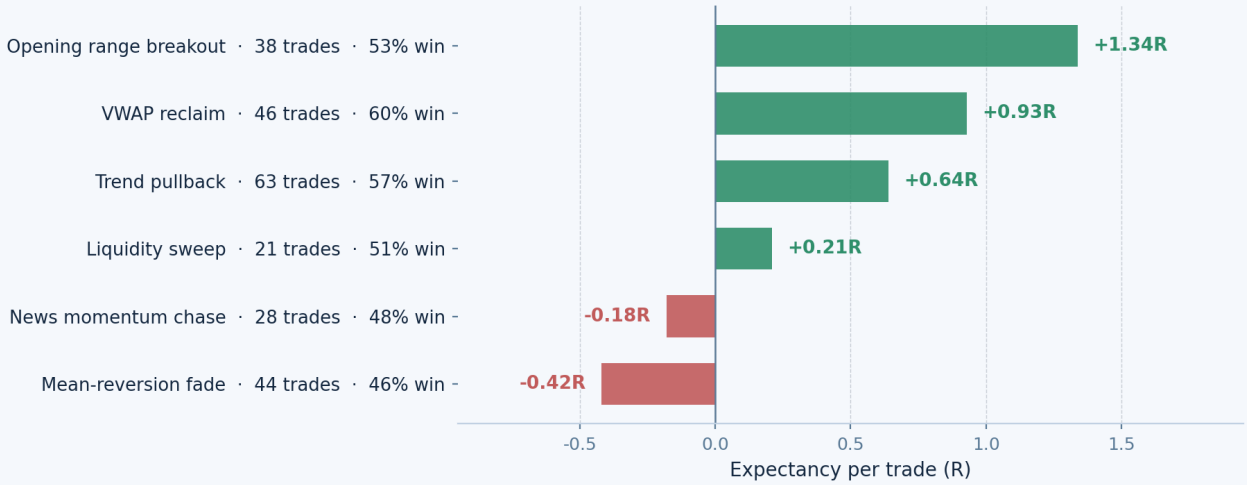


Figure 6 — Expectancy by setup with trade counts and win rates (illustrative data). The playbook's job is to convert this chart into decisions.

The decision rules should be explicit and mechanical. **Kill rule:** any setup whose rolling 30-trade expectancy falls below -0.1R is demoted to paper trading or halved in size. **Promote rule:** any setup sustaining above +0.5R over 30 trades earns a size increase of one step. The journal's final output is never a feeling — it is a position-sizing instruction, and this chart is where it is issued.

7 · The Review Workflow That Makes It Stick

A journal is infrastructure; the review cadence is the product. Every platform failure examined for this report traces to the same root: data accumulated, reviews skipped, insights never surfaced. The cadence below is the minimum viable discipline, and it costs less than two hours a week.

Cadence	Time	What you review	The one question
After every session (daily)	10 min	Tag, grade and note each trade while it is fresh; check the day against the plan	Did I follow my plan?
End of week	30 min	KPI trends, heatmap deltas, the discipline spread, the week's worst mistake tag	Which leak cost me the most this week?
End of month	60 min	Playbook statistics, kill and promote decisions, drawdown review, risk-unit calibration	What do I stop, start, and scale?

Table 7 — The minimum review cadence. Ten minutes daily, thirty weekly, sixty monthly — under two hours a week.

Three habit-design rules keep the cadence alive. Anchor the daily review to session close — same place in the routine, every time, the way a pilot runs a shutdown checklist. Keep a two-minute minimum viable review for bad days: tags and grades only, notes optional, never skip entirely. And treat the weekly review as sacred; it is the loop where the journal earns its subscription, because weekly is the shortest interval at which patterns become statistically visible. A trader who reviews weekly for a year with an honest journal will find at least one six-figure-equivalent leak. That is not motivation — it is what the attribution math in Chapter 2 promises.

8 · Recommendations by Trader Profile

The matrix translates the scoring into purchases. Find the row that matches your bottleneck; the primary pick is where your money should go, the backup is the equally defensible second choice.

Profile	Primary	Backup	Rationale
Analytics-first, multi-asset (this report's brief)	**TradesViz Platinum**	Tradervue Gold	Most statistics per dollar in the category, multi-asset on paid tiers, prop compliance and open data export
Budget-conscious / subscription-averse	**Edgewonk**	Trademetria Basic	$197/year with everything unlocked — psychology included — and no tiers to navigate
AI-automation maximalist	**TradeZella Pro**	TraderSync Premium	Agents tag and review every trade unprompted; the journal maintains itself
Discipline is the known leak	**Edgewonk**	RizeTrade Essential	Tiltmeter and Psychology Lab, or emotion-cost reporting at half the price
Options income (wheel, rolls)	**TradesViz Platinum**	WingmanTracker	Options analytics plus a strategy backtester for roughly half the specialist's price
Futures scalper / prop evaluation	**TradesViz Pro**	Journalytix	Prop compliance across 20 firms; or in-session context if you live in Jigsaw/NinjaTrader
Building the habit, first 90 days	**Tradervue Free**	Stonk Journal	100 imported trades monthly at $0 — verify the habit and your broker import before paying

Table 8 — Recommendations by trader profile, derived from the weighted matrix in Table 3.

For the profile this report was commissioned for — a multi-asset trader buying for personal use with analytics depth as the primary criterion — the recommendation is concrete. Start on TradesViz's free Basic tier this week solely to verify that your brokers import cleanly; move to Platinum (about $270/year) within the month and spend a weekend building the two custom dashboards that answer your questions. Keep Tradervue's free tier as a benchmark for exit analysis — its MFE/MAE reports are worth the second login. If, after a quarter, the discipline spread in Chapter 6's terms turns out to be your real bottleneck, add Edgewonk's behavioral layer rather than switching platforms.

One closing calibration: the tool is perhaps twenty percent of the outcome. The other eighty is the review cadence in Chapter 7 and the honesty of the tags in Chapter 6. The best journal in this report, used weekly, loses to an adequate journal used daily — buy accordingly, and then close the tab and go review your trades.

9 · Sources and Notes

All prices and features were verified against the sources below on 4 November 2026. Vendor pricing in this category changes frequently — TradeZella repriced its full lineup in July 2026 and TraderSync runs rotating first-year promotions — so treat every figure as a snapshot. Several widely-read "best trading journal" rankings that appear high in search results are published by the journals being ranked; where this report relies on such pages, it says so, and cross-checks against independent reviews.

TraderSync. (2026). *Pricing.* https://tradersync.com/pricing

TradeZella. (2026). *Pricing and plans.* https://www.tradezella.com/pricing

TradeZella Help Center. (2026, July 13). *Our pricing.* https://help.tradezella.com/en/articles/8911582-our-pricing

Tradervue. (2026). *7 best trading journals you should use in 2026.* https://www.tradervue.com/blog/best-trading-journal

Edgewonk. (2026). *Pricing.* https://edgewonk.com/pricing

Trademetria. (2026). *Pricing: Free, Basic and Pro plans.* https://trademetria.com/pricing

TradesViz. (2026). *Pricing.* https://www.tradesviz.com/pricing

Rodeck, D. (2026, August 14). *TraderSync review 2026: Pros, cons, and pricing.* StockBrokers.com. https://www.stockbrokers.com/review/tools/tradersync

StockBrokers.com. (2026, August 25). *5 best trading journals for 2026.* https://www.stockbrokers.com/guides/best-trading-journals

Tradeciety. (2026). *Best online trading journals of 2026.* https://tradeciety.com/best-online-trading-journals

Trader's Second Brain. (2026). *TradesViz review 2026: Plans, replay, AI and verdict.* https://traderssecondbrain.com/guides/tradesviz-review

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TradeTanto. (2026). *Journalytix alternative for prop firm traders in 2026.* https://tradetanto.com/learn/journalytix-alternative

TradingDiary Pro. (2026). *Trading journal software for stocks, options, futures and forex.* https://www.tradingdiarypro.com

Plancana. (2026). *Plancana vs Trademetria: Best trading journal for 2026.* https://plancana.com/vs-trademetria

TraderStack. (2026, October 16). *Journalytix — pricing, free plan and alternatives.* https://traderstack.net/tools/journalytix

Note on the illustrative dataset: all figures in Chapter 6 use one synthetic 120-day, 240-trade dataset (seeded, reproducible) so that KPI cards, curves, heatmaps and distributions agree with each other. It demonstrates the blueprint's arithmetic, not any trader's actual results.